

Cartridges—Original Or Refilled?

Many consumers who use inkjet printers opt for cartridge fill-up kits, or visit refill centres after they use their first set of ink cartridges that came bundled with the printer. And why not—after all, you can easily get a refill for around a one-third of what a new cartridge would cost.

Quality doesn't come cheap, however, and using such fill-ups or re-manufactured cartridges can compromise printer components via leakages or deposits, thereby chalking up greater long-term costs due to repairs and possibly even device replacement. There are short-term repercussions, too: refilled cartridges generally do not last as long as originals do, because of the filling and sealing procedures used. And the print quality is almost never as good as with original cartridges.

You might be lucky enough to find a cartridge refiller in your area who does a good job. Many don't, but some do. We can't recommend any refilling companies because refilling your cartridge voids your warranty!

It's a trade-off of sorts. Basically, home users, who always want value, will opt for refills while sacrificing on quality, while for small business houses and the corporate sector, its quality all the way. There is no real solution and the debate goes on; it all depends on what you want from your printer, and to what extent you are willing to trade price with quality.

HP OfficeJet Pro K550

The Speedy Workhorse

Targeted at the office and SoHo segment, this tank (built well, built large), can just as easily be used at home for printing photos. In fact, just using it for monochrome printouts doesn't do it justice at all!

Looks And Features

The K550 pro is a large printer with excellent build quality. It comes with changeable print heads, which is a good thing, as regular use degrades the print heads. The K550 has large individual ink tanks. The paper-in tray can hold 250 sheets—suitable for heavy duty printing.

There's a DTN variant of this printer as well, which has an Ethernet port. The K550DTN costs Rs 5,500 more than this one. Besides the Ethernet port, the models are identical.

Performance

This printer took just 12 and 13 seconds respectively to print our text page at draft and normal settings. The printout at high quality was almost flawless. At draft quality the ink volume seemed a little light; quality, therefore, wasn't too good, but for a business that prints in high volumes and wants to save on ink, this is actually a plus.

Our combi-document took 16 seconds and 34 seconds to print at normal and best quality respec-

tively. At normal settings the printout was a little light: the embedded photo lost out on clarity. The fruits were reproduced well though; we would have liked it if the printer used a little more ink at lower settings. Print quality at high settings was good, with the fruits coming out well with all the highlights. The contrast test was just OK—the K550 missed out on the smallest font even at high settings.

Although not many businesses will use their inkjet to print photos, we nevertheless decided to set this test up. The photo that resulted was adequately-detailed, with all the facial details being captured well. The eyes looked very realistic; the yellow settee came out well; and the shiny red silk coverlet was very vibrant. We noticed a little graininess at one portion of the photo, and took another printout just to be sure—this was not repeated, but the little quirk was noted.

Overall, a very good product that delivers for its price. It is perfectly suited to the SoHo segment, and even to the home user for whom a little extra ink spent at high settings is well worth the quality. ■



HP OfficeJet Pro K550

- Supreme build quality and sturdiness; looks good
 - Suitable for the SoHo segment
 - Individual ink tanks and changeable print heads
 - Very suitable for moderate-volume text printing
 - Moderately suitable for photo printing
 - A bit bulky though
- Price: Rs 7,999



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